manufacturers were not given approvals. An article in BBC titled ‘How India’s vaccine drive went horribly wrong’, written by two Indian freelance journalists, stated, ‘India waited till January to place orders for its vaccines when it could have pre-ordered them much earlier. And it procured such paltry amounts.’[43]

These narratives were far from the truth. See, India operated with the awareness and knowledge that we had manufacturers working and producing vaccines in India. This meant that all production by them would be considered de facto an order for vaccines by the government, especially since it was ultimately the government’s decision on when and how many vaccines could be exported and not totally the vaccine manufacturers’ decision (apart from commitments from contractual obligations which were informed to NEGVAC in advance). Having incubated these companies, NEGVAC did not need to place formal ‘orders’ with any Indian vaccine manufacturers since their entire production was going to be for India.

Politicians from opposition parties and their lurid spokespersons took shots at the government shrieking on prime-time shows on news channels about how the Modi government had failed to protect the people by not having placed enough timely orders for the vaccines. As much as these stories made for great headlines, they didn’t mean much. India was going to consume all vaccines made in the country; there was no doubt about that. As a matter of fact, countries which did need to place orders were those who didn’t have in-house vaccine manufacturing capabilities; several of which despite placing orders in advance didn’t receive the pre-ordered quantities. In fact, some opposition parties rather encouraged white supremacy alluding to the fact that when most major nations of the world were purchasing Pfizer and Moderna vaccines, why weren’t we? They called out the Modi government of being ‘callous’ and ‘cruel’ for failing to do so. Their attitude of holding the international mRNA vaccines in superior light was quickly debunked when research surfaced showing Covaxin having similar levels of efficacy on variants.

On the contrary, the reality was that India was not only one of the five countries to manufacture its own indigenous vaccines but that we were on the cusp of becoming the largest manufacturer of vaccines in the world. Not only would India suffice its own people’s needs but also the needs of a large chunk of the world’s population. The opposition ecosystem’s narrative